hesitation in pushing beyond even their second claim line. Therefore, as a part of their psychological warfare, it firmly planted the seed in the Indian mind that Leh could be the ultimate target.

Among the various troops being moved into Ladakh were 1 Jat, 9 Dogra, 3/4 GR and 3 Sikh LI. Of these, only 1 Jat was allocated to Chushul, while the rest were deployed post-haste for the defence of Leh. On 27 October, the corps commander formally turned down Raina's request for additional troops for the defence of Chushul on the grounds that Leh must remain secure at all cost. All possible routes to Leh were to be held in strength. In the north, two battalions were being deployed to hold Saser-la, Sultan Chushku, Shyok, and the Galwan-Shyok river junction. The route passing over Chang-la was defended at the pass itself and also at Darbuk. Giving depth to the Chang-la defence were the troops deployed at Phobrang and Chushul with some artillery support. In the Indus Valley Sector, 70 Brigade blocked the axis at Dungti, Chumathang, Kiari and areas further back. In Leh proper there was nearly a battalion worth of troops to defend the surrounding hills.

Chinese preparations to take on Gurung Hill and Rezang-la had begun in earnest since July 1962 when they began fortifying their two posts at Military Base and Jechiung. Indian patrols had since reported the setting up of a Chinese OP to the immediate west of Jechiung. Ever since then, Indian troops regularly reported that the PLA was feverishly stocking these positions with ammunition while preparing the necessary gun positions.

A solitary goat track connected Rezang-la to Tsaka-la that was six and a half kilometres to its south. The base camp was almost three kilometres from the forward defences, and Battalion HQ was another ten kilometres from the base. The post was on a telephone line that connected it to Tsaka-la, from where messages were relayed to Battalion HQ. All other posts in the Chushul Sector were too far away to support Rezang-la.

Unfortunately, Raina's 114 Brigade had failed to do anything about the isolation of Rezang-la. Even though the Indian post had been in existence since May 1961 and had been manned by 7 J&K Militia and then 1/8 GR, there were no bunkers or trenches owing to the rock hard terrain. Indian troops had instead built stone sangars that only had tin roofs for protection. There were no sandbags or even mud to cover the tin, which made the sangars death traps if exposed to artillery or RCL fire. The stone used for the construction was brittle and tended to splinter, magnifying the